value six months ahead of general elections. What it hopes to do is tap into the disenchantment of the youth and lasso in OBC voters. With no dearth of resources, the BJP is also wooing middle-rung TRS and Congress leaders. But the party seems to lack the organisational strength on the ground needed to mount a sustained state-wide campaign against the TRS. This is where KCR sees an advantage; hence his well-oiled party machinery is focusing on mobilisation of voters at the booth level.

The image of KCR as a benevolent authority figure, however, has been eroded over the years, says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University of Law. "He has no option now but to be aggressive and deliver on his promises. This was evident in the way he inaugurated medical colleges online from Pragathi Bhavan (his official residence) on November 15," Vageeshan adds. KCR inaugurated eight medical colleges and promised to open 17 more in the next two years so that there is at least one state-run medical college in each of the 33 districts. The final year of his term may not be the earliest he could have done this, but he's at that stage where the old adage—better late than never—buzzes with a certain urgency. ■

RAJASTHAN

A QUESTION OF GENDER LAW

By Rohit Parihar

In a society where it is still an uphill battle for women who seek justice in cases of gender-related crime, instances of women filing allegedly false cases of rape or dowry harassment form a contentious layer of legal action that has polarised the field. Taking serious note of what is seen as a misuse of laws intended to protect women, the Rajasthan State Commission of Women has advised the police to take strict action against women whose complaints are found to be false. But this has made women's groups and human rights organisations see red. On November 2, activists stormed into the commission's Jaipur office protesting against what they call a regressive move that could increase the vulnerability of female survivors.

Women activists say while anyone making false accusations can attract legal action, it is not the commission's mandate to recommend action against complainants. "Nowhere else in India and never before in Rajasthan has a women's commission taken such a stand," says Kavita Srivastava, president of the People's Union for Civil Liberties (PUCL), Rajasthan. In a memorandum submitted to the commission's chairperson Rehana Riyaz, several women's organisations said they were "extremely disappointed" by the "anti-women stand and action".

The debate began after Riyaz, who took over as the commission chairperson in February, expressed anguish over a large number of complaints turning out false and claimed women were taking "undue advantage" of laws meant to protect them. She said the commission identified 418 such cases and asked the police to see if complainants in 60 of them could be proceeded against. "It's wrong to say we are ordering prosecution or are biased against complainants. Rather, we are ensuring the law is not gender-biased and investigations are fair towards both complainant and accused," she said.

Her stand seems to flow from CM



RAISING THE ISSUE Rajasthan State Commission of Women chairperson Rehana Riyaz

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR